

Got To Eat Your Vegetables

T.S

“Time for dinner!” Mum’s tone was sweet yet it filled me with fear.

My stomach groaned in hunger despite my brain’s protest. Last time I refused I was sent to my room. I needed to eat. But I didn’t want to, I didn’t want to!

Dad put his hand over my shoulder as I sat on the couch.

“Didn’t you hear? Time to come to the table.”

I walked with trepidation, each foot I placed down made me shiver.

A white cloth with roses hung over a circular table, the pink plates sat snug next to silver knives and forks, a platter of roast in the centre.

I pointedly ignored the large clear bowl of salad. I couldn’t drown out their whimpers though.

Mum was already sitting, and when I joined, she deposited a few slices of red, glistening meat onto my plate.

“Gravy?”

I nodded and once the brown sauce was lathered on, grabbed my cutlery to begin eating.

“Hold on Winton. Everyone needs to be served before you can eat.

Not to mention you haven’t got everything yet. Veggies?”

My jaw tightened.

“No thank you.”

Dad shook his head as he joined us.

“How many times have we talked about this son. You need to eat your vegetables.”

I felt my throat constrict. But there was no point in arguing.

“Oh my baby, it’s not that bad. Look at me, just chew,” Mum forked something on her plate and began eating, “and swallow!”

I didn’t see what she had grabbed, I was making sure to look away, both fingers shoved deep inside my ears.

“Winton!” Dad’s voice whipped into me.

“Look at your mother when she shows you.”

I wiped a tear. And looked as she speared another portion.

The shred of lettuce stared at me with wide green eyes, each of its ribs moving in agony as its howls reached fever pitch. A cherry tomato, just a baby, screamed at the raw metal entrenched in its abdomen, at how it was going to die before its life had really begun.

I tasted bile when those cries of pain dimmed to nothing as the cherry child was crunched between my Mum’s white teeth.

“See, it’s easy!” She smiled at me, the tomato’s blood dribbling down her chin.

I forced the words out in a whisper.

“I’ll just eat the meat first and ...”

“No, no.” Dad interrupted. “You’ll eat a couple bites of your veggies first.

Go on.

Do it.”

I felt my face scrunch up.

“I ... I can’t ...”

Mum slammed her hand on the table. It was still clutching the knife. How many families, how many children, had that piece of silver ended?

“Winton! You’re almost nine years old! You’re a big boy now. It’s time to grow up and eat your greens. You’re not leaving until you’ve had a mouthful!” She used the salad server to spoon a portion onto my plate.

I stared down at the mewling figures below me.

The lettuce trembled, the tomatoes cried and the cucumber screamed.

I tried to use my fork to scoop some up and fumbled bringing it to my mouth, spilling most back onto the plate.

“Seriously,” Dad grabbed a cucumber that had fallen onto the table, I whimpered as it was thrown into the yawning abyss of his throat. How far down the black would it fall screaming?

I steeled myself and with a shiver, speared a tomato.

I raised it to my mouth, trying to ignore its shrieks, the eyes that stared at me with fear, the words it said begging me to return it to its children.

So I listened to my own stomach, that was empty, that NEEDED food.

“It’s just a vegetable Winton.”

A difficult concept to understand when the vegetable's blood is leaking onto your tablecloth.

With a howl I threw it down my gullet and swallowed.

"Good boy!" Dad patted me on the back.

I wanted to cry.

But most of all I was ashamed.

By the fact that it tasted good.

And how the squealing vegetables on my plate now looked so ... tasty.